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WOOL AS RITUAL?

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Wool as Ritual?

Wool has been valued since prehistoric times for its ability to provide warmth and comfort. However, it became not only a material that made life more pleasant, but also a symbol that influenced the development of society. Sheep were often depicted as a symbol of innocence and gentleness, which was reflected in religious and cultural imagery. Over the semester, we focused on the topic of religious fetish. We found connections between ancient rituals, talismans and amulets, Christian artifacts and compared them with the contemporary context. We found the interconnectedness of these concepts interesting.

In ancient times, wool was important mainly in healing rituals. Medicine was closely related to faith and religion. Diseases were believed to be caused by supernatural forces. In ancient Mesopotamia, where sheep were first domesticated, wool was attributed magical properties.[1]

Amulets and talismans were made from wool and various healing rituals are described where it played a significant role. It appears in different colors for different purposes. The motif of spinning wool and wrapping yarn is often repeated. It was also combined with various materials, for example with semi-precious stones or copper, thus forming a kind of amulet.[2]

These amulets were used as protection against danger.[3] Wool in ancient Egypt was not of the same quality as in Mesopotamia, but it was used to make offerings, among other things, to protect on the way to the afterlife. Lucky charms made from woolen yarn were popular in antiquity. The Golden Fleece was a symbol of royal power, according to Greek legend. In ancient Rome, records were found of a ritual in which people threw woolen offerings into the Tiber River. These were dolls sold by priests, symbolically replacing human sacrifices.[4]

Christianity works mainly with symbols. References to wool accompany the Bible in various forms. An important concept is the sacrificial lamb or lamb of God (Agnus Dei), a symbol of Jesus Christ. Jesus is depicted as a shepherd and people as his flock.[5] In the Middle Ages, an amulet appeared, a kind of medal made from the wax of Easter candles, which bore the

1 Dilek, Yeşim, and Pınar Gözlük Kırmızıoğlu. 2022. "Varicolored Wool in Ancient Treatment Rituals." Istanbul Anthropological Review 0, no. 2: 61-68. https://doi.org/10.26650/IAR2022-1183927 2022, issue 2

2 Dilek, Yeşim, and Pınar Gözlük Kırmızıoğlu. 2022, ibidem

3 Dilek, Yeşim, and Pınar Gözlük Kırmızıoğlu. 2022, ibidem

4 María Julia Martínez-García, "That highly prized textile fiber: wool as a magical and medicinal remedy", MedCrave, 2023, issue 3 https://medcraveonline.com/JTEFT/JTEFT-09-00336.pdf

5 Jaroslav Studený, Křesťanské symboly, (Olomouc: B.n. 1992), 369.

motif of the Lamb of God.[6] The Golden Fleece appears in the Old Testament as a symbol of victory. The idiom "wolf in sheep's clothing" is also taken from the bible.[7]

Following this, we created a series of ritual objects. In addition to wool, we also used other materials:namely, wax, metal, wood, and lanolin soap. Working with these materials and the combination thereof refers to ritualism in their very processing. We worked the wool using the dryfelting technique, we approached it sculpturally, testing what density it can withstand and how it can be shaped. Beeswax is a reference to votive objects and offerings. We created different variations of the sacrifice lamb. Metal was another alternative approach for us. Some selected symbols, such as the Golden Fleece or the Lamb of God, are made from it. The biggest object has a skeleton made of wood, which is covered in lanolin soap. This is a form of experiment. At the same time, lanolin continues the line of rituals, it is added to cosmetics, for example to anti-aging creams or hair products.

We are fascinated by the apparent respect for the material that people had and that we often miss. At the same time, we put emphasis on spirituality and grounding. This work is not only a celebration of wool as a material, but also a challenge to think about its diverse functions.

6 John Paul Sonnen, "The Paschal Blessing of the "Agnus Dei", Liturgical Arts Journal, issue April 2020 https://www.liturgicalartsjournal.com/2020/04/the-paschal-blessing-of-agnus-dei.html?m=1

7 "Matthew 7:15-21" (Matthew chapter 7, verse 15), Bible https://www.bible.com/bible/111/MAT.7.15-21.NIV date of searching March 14, 2024